

[Lesson 16](#): “Thou Shalt ... Offer Up Thy Sacraments upon My Holy Day” (See L16 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help strengthen our desire to keep the Sabbath day holy.

1. The Lord established the Sabbath.

• Genesis 2:2-3; Exodus 20:8-11; 31:13-17. †1. Alexis De Tocqueville described early 1830 America

2. Pay devotions to God by worshiping Him in Sunday Church meetings.

• D&C 59. Bible Dictionary “Sabbath” 764-65 †2. Robert L. Millet

President Gordon B. Hinckley said that “every sacrament meeting ought to be a spiritual feast” and “a time of spiritual refreshment.” (Teachings of Gordon B. Hinckley [1997], 563, 564)

President Spencer W. Kimball: “We do not go to Sabbath meetings to be entertained or even solely to be instructed. We go to worship the Lord. It is an individual responsibility, and regardless of what is said from the pulpit, if one wishes to worship the Lord in spirit and truth, he may do so by attending his meetings, partaking of the sacrament, and contemplating the beauties of the gospel. If the service is a failure to you, you have failed. No one can worship for you.” (“The Sabbath—A Delight,” Ensign, Jan. 1978, 4-5)

Elder Boyd K. Packer said, “an increasing number of our leaders and members do not sing the congregational songs.” He then counseled, “We should sing the songs of Zion—they are an essential part of our worship.” (Ensign, Nov. 1991, 22)

Elder Boyd K. Packer said we should be reverent in the chapel so we do not intrude “when someone is struggling to feel delicate spiritual communications.” He also cautioned that reverence “does not equate with absolute silence. We must be tolerant of little babies, even an occasional outburst from a toddler being ushered out.” (Ensign, Nov. 1991, 22)

3. Pay devotions to God by partaking of the sacrament.

• D&C 59:9, 12. †3. Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin
How can parents help prepare their children for this ordinance?
†4. Elder M. Russell Ballard

4. Pay devotions to God by resting from your labors.

†5. Presiding Bishop H. David Burton †6. President Spencer W. Kimball †7. President Spencer W. Kimball

President Gordon B. Hinckley: “Let the Latter-day Saints be in their homes, teaching their families, reading the scriptures, doing things that are wholesome and beautiful and communing with the Lord on the Sabbath day.” (Ensign, July 1996, 73)

President Gordon B. Hinckley: “Now I do not want to be prudish. I do not want you to lock your children in the house and read the Bible all afternoon to them. Be wise. Be careful. But make that day a day when you can sit down with your families and talk about sacred and good things.” (Teachings of Gordon B. Hinckley, 559-60)

5. The Lord blesses those who keep the Sabbath day holy.

• D&C 59:9-10, 12-17; Isaiah 58:13-14.
What blessings does the Lord promise to those who keep the Sabbath day holy?

†8. Dennis R. Peterson’s story

Next Week: Lesson 17: The Law of Tithing and the Law of the Fast; See L17 [Class Member Study Guide](#).
(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. Alexis De Tocqueville described the America he saw in the early 1830s: “In the United States on the seventh day of every week the trading and working life of the nation seems suspended; all noises cease; a deep tranquility, say rather the solemn calm of meditation, succeeds the turmoil of the week, and the soul resumes possession and contemplation of itself. On this day the marts of traffic are deserted; every member of the community, accompanied by his children, goes to church, where he listens to strange language which would seem unsuited to his ear. He is told of the countless evils caused by pride and covetousness; he is reminded of the necessity of checking his desires, of the finer pleasures that belong to virtue alone, and of the true happiness that attends it. On his return home he does not turn to the ledgers of his business, but he opens the book of Holy Scripture; there he meets with sublime and affecting descriptions of the greatness and goodness of the Creator, of the infinite magnificence of the handiwork of God, and of the lofty destinies of man, his duties, and his immortal privileges.

“Thus it is that the American at times steals an hour from himself, and, laying aside for a while the petty passions which agitate his life, and the ephemeral interests which engross it, he strays at once into an ideal world, where all is great, eternal, and pure.

“I have endeavored to point out, in another part of this work, the causes to which the maintenance of the political institutions of the Americans is attributable, and religion appeared to be one of the most prominent among them. I am now treating of the Americans in an individual capacity, and I again observe that religion is not less useful to each citizen than to the whole state...” (Alexis De Tocqueville, *Democracy in America*, Vol. 2, 1972, Alfred P. Knopf, Inc., 143)

†2. Robert L. Millet: “We live in trying times. We are surrounded by gross wickedness—indecent, immorality, abuse, harshness, crudeness, and insensitivity to the things of God. To keep us from yielding to the persuasions of the worldly, the Lord has provided a sacred institution we call the Church. Attending Church meetings focuses our minds, for at least three hours a week, on things that matter. Attending Church meetings puts us in contact with people of goodwill, people who have the same desires for time and eternity that we do. Attending Church meetings allows us to learn and grow and develop; it also allows us to give and share and strengthen others.” (*Alive in Christ: The Miracle of Spiritual Rebirth*, 140-141)

†3. Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin: “Windows must be washed regularly to clean away dust and dirt.... Just as earthly windows need consistent, thorough cleaning, so do the windows of our spirituality.... By partaking of the sacrament worthily to renew our baptismal covenants, we clarify our view of life’s eternal purpose and divine priorities. The sacrament prayers invite personal introspection, repentance, and rededication as we pledge our willingness to remember our Savior, Jesus the Christ.” (“[Windows of Light and Truth](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1995, 77)

†4. Elder M. Russell Ballard: “After His mortal ministry, ... Jesus told his Nephite Apostles that He would no longer accept burnt offerings but that His disciples should offer ‘a broken heart and a contrite spirit (3 Ne. 9:19-20; see also D&C 59:8, 12). Instead of the Lord requiring our animals or grain, now He wants us to give up all that is ungodly. This higher practice of the law of sacrifice reaches into the inner soul of a person....

“... When we overcome our own selfish desires and put God first in our lives and covenant to serve Him regardless of the cost, we are then living the law of sacrifice.” (“[The Law of Sacrifice](#),” *Ensign*, Oct. 1998, 10-11)

†5. Presiding Bishop H. David Burton: “Now, I know it’s hard, particularly for our young people, to choose to observe the Sabbath day when athletic teams on which they so much want to participate regularly schedule games on Sunday. I too know it seems trivial to many who are in need of just a few items on the Sabbath to quickly stop at a convenience store to make a Sunday purchase. But I also know that remembering to keep the Sabbath day holy is one of the most important commandments we can observe in preparing us to be the recipients of the whisperings of the Spirit.” (“[A Season of Opportunity](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1998, 9)

†6. President Spencer W. Kimball: “The Sabbath is a holy day in which to do worthy and holy things. Abstinence from work and recreation is important, but insufficient. The Sabbath calls for constructive thoughts and acts, and if one merely lounges about doing nothing on the Sabbath, he is breaking it. To observe it, one will be on his knees in prayer, preparing lessons, studying the gospel, meditating, visiting the ill and distressed, writing letters to missionaries, taking a nap, reading wholesome material, and attending all the meetings of that day at which he is expected.” (“[The Sabbath—A Delight](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1978, 4)

†7. President Spencer W. Kimball: “We may want to set aside time for our family to be together, for personal study and meditation, and for service to others. We might want to read the scriptures, conference reports, and Church publications; study the lives and teachings of the prophets; prepare church lessons and other church assignments; write in journals; pray and meditate; write to or visit relatives and friends; write to missionaries; enjoy uplifting music; have family gospel instruction; hold family council meetings; build husband-wife relationships; read with a child; do genealogical research, including the four-generation program and family or personal histories; sing Church hymns; read uplifting literature; develop our appreciation of the cultural arts; plan family home evening study and activities; plan other family activities; friendship nonmembers; fellowship neighbors; visit the sick, the aged, and the lonely; hold interviews with family members.” (“[Therefore I Was Taught](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1982, 3)

Further Enrichment Resources:

Doctrine and Covenants Student Manual, (pp. 127-128)

D&C 59:9–10. Pay Thy Devotion unto the Most High
President John Taylor said: “To serve the Lord, is one of the great objects of our existence; and I appreciate as a great privilege the opportunity we enjoy of worshiping God on the Sabbath day. **And when we do meet to worship God, I like to see us worship him with all our hearts. I think it altogether out of place on such occasions to hear people talk about secular things;** these are times, above all others perhaps, when our feelings and affections should be drawn out towards God. **If we sing praises to God, let us do it in the proper spirit; if we pray, let every soul be engaged in prayer, doing it with all our hearts, that through our union our spirits may be blended in one,** that our prayers and our worship may be available with God, whose Spirit permeates all things, and is always present in the assemblies of good and faithful Saints.” (In *Journal of Discourses*, 22:226.)

D&C 59:11–12. What Is an Oblation?

Elder Bruce R. McConkie defined an oblation in the highest sense as “giving full devotion to the Lord, of offering him a broken heart and a contrite spirit. (D. & C. 59:8–12, 3 Ne. 9:19–20.) In a lesser and more temporal sense, **an oblation is the offering of sacrifices, or of fast offering, or of any charitable contribution to the Church. (Ezek. 44:30.)** Isaiah spoke of vain oblations meaning the ritualistic offering of sacrifices when the spirit and meaning of the ordinance and offering had been lost. (Isa. 1:13.) Ezekiel foretold that oblations would again be offered by Israel in the day of gathering. (Ezek. 20:33–44.)” (*Mormon Doctrine*, pp. 541–42.)

D&C 59:13. “That Thy Fasting May Be Perfect”

President Joseph F. Smith: “Now, while the law requires the Saints in all the world to fast from ‘even to even’ and to abstain both from food and drink, **it can easily be seen from the Scriptures, and especially from the words of Jesus, that it is more important to obtain the true spirit of love for God and man, ‘purity of heart and simplicity of intention,’ than it is to carry out the cold letter of the law. The Lord has instituted the fast on a reasonable and intelligent basis, and none of his works are vain or unwise.** His law is perfect in this as in other things. **Hence, those who can are required to comply thereto; it is a duty from which they cannot escape; but let it be remembered that the observance of the fast day by abstaining twenty-four hours from food and drink is not an absolute rule,** it is no iron-clad law to us, but it is left with the people as a matter of conscience, to exercise wisdom and discretion. **Many are subject to weakness, others are delicate in health, and others have nursing babies; of such it should not be required to fast. Neither should parents compel their little children to fast. I have known children to cry for something to eat on fast day. In such cases, going without food will do them no good. Instead, they dread the day to come, and in place of hailing it, dislike it; while the compulsion engenders a spirit of rebellion in them, rather than a love for the Lord and their fellows. Better teach them the principle, and let them observe it when they are old enough to choose intelligently, than to so compel them.**

“But those should fast who can, and all classes among us should be taught to save the meals which they would eat, or their equivalent, for the poor. **None are exempt from this; it is required of the Saints, old and young, in every part of the Church.** It is no excuse that in some places there are no poor. In such cases the fast donation should be forwarded to the proper authorities for transmission to such stakes of Zion as may stand in need.” (*Gospel Doctrine*, pp. 243–44.)

D&C 59:16–20. Is There a Relationship between the Richness of the Earth and the Righteousness of the People?

One of the prominent themes of the Book of Mormon is that “as ye shall keep my commandments, ye shall prosper” (1 Nephi 2:20). **“Prosper” implies more than an accumulation of physical wealth, but temporal prosperity is included in that blessing.** Moses told the Israelites, “It shall come to pass, if ye hearken to these judgments, and keep, and do them, that . . . he will love thee, and bless thee, and multiply thee: he will also bless the fruit of thy womb, and the fruit of thy land, thy corn, and thy wine, and thine oil, the increase of thy kine [cattle], and the flocks of thy sheep, in the land which he swear unto thy fathers to give thee” (Deuteronomy 7:12–13). The Lord promises to bless the land as well as the people.

In section 59 the Lord again promises temporal blessings for spiritual obedience, including obedience to the law of the Sabbath. **After a serious drought had ravaged the western United States, President Spencer W. Kimball asked if such a natural calamity might not be related to the obedience of the people, especially their observance of the Sabbath.**

“The Lord uses the weather sometimes to discipline his people for the violation of his laws. He said to the children of Israel:

“‘If ye walk in my statutes, and keep my commandments, and do them;

“‘Then I will give you rain in due season, and the land shall yield her increase, and the trees of the field shall yield their fruit.

“‘And your threshing shall reach into the vintage, and the vintage shall reach unto the sowing time; and ye shall eat your bread to the full, and dwell in your land safely.

“‘And I will give peace in the land, and ye shall lie down, and none shall make you afraid: . . . neither shall the sword go through your land.’ (Lev. 26:3–6.) . . .

“Perhaps the day has come when we should take stock of ourselves and see if we are worthy to ask or if we have been breaking the commandments, making ourselves unworthy of receiving the blessings. . . . “(**The Lord Expects His Saints to Follow the Commandments**,” *Ensign*, May 1977, p. 4–5.)

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†9. Dennis R. Peterson,
“[To Love the Things God Loves](#),”
Ensign, Mar 1981, 6

... Elder James E. Talmage in *Jesus the Christ* explained that the Savior “had the capacity, the ability to sin had He willed so to do. ... Nevertheless his insurance against [sin] ... is not that of external compulsion, but of internal restraint due to his cultivated companionship of the spirit of truth” (Salt Lake City: Deseret Book, 1973, p. 134).

It was a moment of real revelation for me. I understood finally that Christ’s ultimate defense was not his supreme willpower but simply that, nurtured by the Spirit, he had no desire for Satan’s grimy alternatives. He loved the things his Father loves. Thus, as his desires flowed into deeds, those deeds reflected a spontaneous righteousness that came from the very depths of his being.

That was the key: to love the things God loves, to make his desires my own, and thus to be truly like him. My problem was that I had been trying to act in godly ways while wanting ungodly things. If I could change the desires of my heart, then my actions would spontaneously become godly.

I felt a kind of hope I had not felt before. I went back to the scriptures, seeking hungrily to learn what God loves. Mormon put the explanation into words for me. What I wanted was charity, which was “the pure love of Christ.” And I could receive it if I would “pray unto the Father *with all the energy of heart*, that ye may be filled with this love, which he hath bestowed upon all who are true followers of his Son, Jesus Christ.” And Mormon also included the promise I needed: “that ye may become the sons of God; ... that we may be purified even as he is pure” (Moro. 7:47–48; italics added).

I felt the lists of commandments and precepts suddenly transformed by power—the power to change not only appearances but feelings, loves, and desires.

Cautiously, I chose my first target. It wasn’t very earthshaking, but it was a persistent problem. I didn’t enjoy attending church. So, morning and night, I would pray: “Lord, bless me to feel about our worship services just the way thou dost. Help me to find in them the things that thou wouldst find. Help me to participate in the ways that thou wouldst.” And tremendous things began to happen. Sunday became a day filled with light; I found myself hungry to greet the other members of the Church, to share my testimony with them, to learn from the teachers, to express in song the feelings I had no words for, and to partake of the emblems of our Savior’s sacrifice with humility and gratitude. Sunday became a Sabbath. No longer was attending church a matter of suppressing my desire to rest,

read, study, ski, or play. Now it was an expression of righteous, loving desires.

....

Another challenge was an individual I had to work closely with. I felt no particular admiration for him, and he obviously held me in great disdain. As our interchanges grew more prickly, I found him deliberately trying to sabotage my work and needling me to provoke quarrels. I responded in the best tradition of the natural man and soon a bitter feud was underway. In my quieter moments, I realized that I was destroying myself and that the Spirit was leaving me because of this contention.

Again, I turned to the Lord and prayed, night and morning, “Father, I’m having a terrible time with this man. Wilt thou bless me that I may feel about him as thou dost.” Soon a vision began to open to me of an entirely different person than the one I’d been perceiving. I now saw a sensitive, easily hurt individual who felt alone, vulnerable, and afraid in new situations. I began to see the great strengths he had developed that had brought him to this point.

But more, I gradually came to feel reverence and even awe for him. Here was a son of God, beloved and cherished of him. And who could resist loving such a person? Not I. It came. The love just came. Another small corner of my heart had been changed, and the Lord’s promise had been fulfilled.

My experience has been that it may take weeks of pleading with the Lord at least twice a day for these changes to come. But they *will* come, and, if we “press forward with a steadfastness in Christ, having a perfect brightness of hope, and a love of God and of all men,” we need not lose those feelings of joy and peace (2 Ne. 31:20)...

Notes:

Dennis R. Peterson, “[To Love the Things God Loves](#),” *Ensign*, Mar. 1981, 6.

[Note: When Dennis R. Peterson wrote this article, he was a physician, and an elders quorum president in his Bountiful, Utah, ward.]

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